

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Mass layoffs start at health agencies

As Trump dismantles EPA, Great Lakes states will suffer, experts say

By Michael Hawthorne
Chicago Tribune

Dirty air remains a chronic problem in the Chicago area. Shortly before President Joe Biden left office, the U.S. Environmental Protection Agency reclassified the region from “moderate” to “serious” violations of federal regulations limiting lung-damaging smog, also known as ground-level ozone. Better understanding about the dangers of particulate matter, commonly known as soot, prompted the Biden EPA to tighten

federal standards, effectively requiring cleaner factories, power plants and vehicles. Under normal circumstances, failure to take more aggressive action to clear the air could cost Illinois hundreds of millions of dollars in road-building funds and make it more difficult for polluters to obtain permits. Industry executives and regulators would hash out new plans to improve air quality. But Donald Trump is president again. **Turn to EPA, Page 2**



Employees wait outside the Health and Human Services headquarters building Tuesday in Washington. **AMANDA SEITZ/AP**

Up to 10,000 could be cut; Workers learn fate via emails, disabled badges

By Carla K. Johnson
Associated Press

Employees across the wide-ranging U.S. Health and Human Services Department began receiving notices of dismissal Tuesday in an overhaul ultimately expected to lay off up to 10,000 people. The cuts include researchers, scientists, doctors, support staff and senior leaders, leaving the federal government without many of the key experts who have long guided U.S. decisions on medical research, drug approvals and other

issues. At the National Institutes of Health, the world’s leading health and medical agency, the layoffs occurred as its new director, Dr. Jay Bhattacharya, began his first day of work. “The revolution begins today!” Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. wrote on social media as he celebrated the swearing-in of his latest hires: Bhattacharya and Martin Makary, the new Food and Drug Administration commissioner. Kennedy’s post came just **Turn to Health, Page 5**

ELECTION 2025



STACEY WESCOTT/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Suburban voters hit the polls

Luka Fuentes, 2, looks at the ballot of his grandmother, Maria Zea, at the Warehouse Church in Aurora on Tuesday. It was Election Day in some suburbs and Aurora’s mayoral contest was among the high-profile races as incumbent Richard Irvin tries to hold off Ald. John Laesch in his reelection bid. Check for coverage of these races and more at chicagotribune.com/elections.

Debate resumes over 8 p.m. curfew for teens downtown

Boy shot during ‘teen takeover’ in Streeterville on Friday

By Rebecca Johnson
and Jake Sheridan
Chicago Tribune

Michele Lee decided to go outside with her neighbor in the warm, fresh air Friday evening. Lee, who uses a wheelchair, went over to Navy Pier and back to a pet store near her Streeterville apartment. As she made her way home, she said she heard lots of yelling and saw hundreds of teenagers gathered on the street in front of her building. They didn’t move for pedestrians. At that point, she said she started to feel unsafe. “I couldn’t even go into my door,” she said. “I had to flag down a bicycle policeman to take me across the street. I have a wheelchair — it’s not like I can run away or easily weave through people.” Videos of the so-called teen

takeover circulated on social media Friday night, showing young people running through the streets. Chicago police reported that a 15-year-old boy sustained a graze wound to his leg. Meanwhile, another teen was arrested Monday morning for allegedly shooting a tourist last month in the same area as she was walking back to her hotel with her 11-year-old son. Residents, including a Streeterville neighborhood group, are now calling on Mayor Brandon Johnson to stop the “reckless and unlawful behavior.” A downtown alderman has also promised to revive a stalled City Council bid to install an 8 p.m. unaccompanied minor curfew. Johnson has resisted calls in the past for an earlier curfew, including last summer after a group of teens attacked a couple in Streeterville. On Tuesday he told reporters he was more interested in how to “invest in young people and create more healthy **Turn to Curfew, Page 4**



A Chicago police evidence technician processes the scene at 455 N. Cityfront Plaza Drive in Chicago after a disturbance in the area on March 28. **TERRENCE ANTONIO JAMES/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

“I don’t want to go outside of my house after dark now. It makes me — even talking about it right now — it’s making me shake a little because I’m scared for another warm weather day.”

— Michele Lee, who lives in Streeterville

‘Different approach’ led to deal with CTU

Bargaining wraps up with no strike, but how will it affect students?

By Nell Salzman and Alice Yin
Chicago Tribune

The Chicago Teachers Union team of 65 educators voted in favor of a proposed settlement Monday evening that wrapped up close to a year of negotiations with the school district. Tuesday morning at a news conference, CTU celebrated its hard-fought gains for students and educators. Stacy Davis Gates, president of the teachers union said the district “spent a lot of time marginalizing (the) table.” She reiterated the strong priorities and values baked into the contract. “We’re not closing schools, we’re not giving money to the oligarchy and the elite of this city. We are, quite frankly, resourcing the people who have been deprived of it for generations,” she said. “This city can do a lot when it is clearly connected to the community.” Notably, under a friendly mayor, the third-largest teachers union in the nation wrapped up bargaining for the first time in a decade without a strike vote or strike. A vote from the 730-member House of Delegates on Wednesday is the next step in ratification. A full 30,000 membership vote and approval from the Chicago Board of Education will seal the deal. CPS Chief Executive Officer Pedro Martinez told reporters several hours after it was approved Monday that this year’s process was a “different approach” and even “collaborative.” Considering the months of discussion both sides put into reaching a deal and the political drama that led up to its final days, any insinuation of harmony might seem to onlookers like April Fools’.

“Regardless of what some of the narratives were out there, there’s never been a moment where my team didn’t act in good faith,” Martinez said. “Did we get sometimes frustrated about misinformation that was shared? Yes, we did, because we’re human, and there was a lot going on.” Still, the CEO, who is leaving his position in June after Mayor Brandon Johnson, a former CTU organizer, led an effort to fire him for not taking out a loan, spoke Monday night about the hard work that his staff put into the new teachers contract — under financially extenuating circumstances. Martinez said the proposed contract will cost about \$1.5 billion **Turn to Contract, Page 5**

New to the scene

Kanin, a Filipino Hawaiian bodega in Ravenswood, opens with lines two blocks long. The musubi has become the staple that holds the shop together. **Food & Health**

Trump’s Joint Chiefs pick testifies

Retired Air Force Lt. Gen. Dan “Razin” Caine told senators he would be candid with the President Donald Trump and vowed to be apolitical. **Nation & World**

Members of the club

Cubs shortstop Dansby Swanson and second baseman Nico Hoerner are using torpedos bats — and seeing results. **Chicago Sports**

